

# RALLYING FOR reform

## FIRST-WAVE FEMINISM

From the mid-19th century onward, there was a growing demand for women's rights. The Enlightenment and subsequent revolutions (see pp.130–133) had brought sweeping changes to Western society, yet the traditional role of women remained mostly unaltered. This changed as activists came together in the first wave of feminism, so called to distinguish it from the second wave of the 1960s.

Earlier women had played a vital role in campaigning for change across a number of issues, ranging from the abolition of slavery to prison reform. However, many now turned their attention to the growing women's rights cause, which was being championed by women such as Mary Wollstonecraft, an English advocate for women's education. A founding event in first-wave feminism was the Seneca Falls Convention, held in July 1848 in upstate New York, an area home to many radical Quakers. The main organizers were the abolitionists Lucretia Coffin Mott and Elizabeth Cady Stanton. Together they wrote

the Declaration of Sentiments and Grievances, which called for equal rights for women. Although only around 300 people, including men, attended the convention, it served as a catalyst for later campaigning in the US.

### An expanding movement

In the UK, the Langham Place Circle, named after the location of the *English Woman's Journal*, provided a forum for the exchange of ideas by women. In 1855, they founded the Married Women's Property Committee to demand reform of the British laws of coverture. These laws stated that after a woman married, all of her money, property, and earnings were transferred to her spouse. The committee's work led Parliament to pass the Married Women's Property Act in 1870, which made a woman's wages and property separate from those of her husband.

The drive for greater rights for women began to spread further afield. A few weeks before Seneca Falls, a conference was held in

Badasht, Persia (modern Iran), where women discussed gender equality in the Bábí religion. In Europe, several national groups were founded including the General German Women's Association in 1865, the French Society for the Demand for Women's Rights in 1866, and the Danish Women's Society in 1871. In early 1888, the first meeting of the International Council of Women took place in Washington, D.C. Its members publicized the women's movement, laying the foundations for the later campaigns for suffrage.

### ► In search of equality

The US National Woman Suffrage Association was founded by Susan B. Anthony and Elizabeth Cady Stanton in 1869. Satirized here, it spoke out on issues such as inequality in jobs and pay.

